STATE SCAN

MP: NOT SUCH A UNIFORM CODE *PG 13*

KERALA: RAINING ERRORS IN WAYANAD *PG 16*

PRABHJOT GILL





THE CLASH From left, CM Mann; acting jathedar Gargaj after Akal Takht meeting, July 8

IANS

▶ PUNJAB

THE JATT AND THE JATHEDAR

A never-before contest for space between religious authority and state—CM Mann is chastened but still combating Gargaj

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

IT WAS A BATTLE AS SHARP AS THE EDGE OF A KIRPAN, AND THE Bhagwant Mann government has feinted—but not blinked. Not yet at least. The one-month ultimatum is closing on July 29. It was an unusually stormy month too, with the controversial Diljit Dosanjh starrer *Satluj* streaking across the landscape like a high-voltage line. But through all that, the Aam Aadmi Party's chief minister held on—tactfully toning down his Jack-in-the-box persona, but with no real signs of surrender. If the deadline passes without event, the focus will shift to the one who issued the *firman*: Akal Takht acting jathedar Giani Kuldeep Singh Gargaj.

Can the Akal Takht make its word stick? Can its moral authority be converted into binding pressure without slipping into partisan combat? The object in the centre of these questions is an anti-sacrilege law, the Jagat Jyot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Act, 2026. Why would that run afoul of the clergy? They say it was drafted without seeking the opinion of panthic authorities, and contains vocabulary that amounts to state overreach.

The core grievance: the law ignored the 1959 pact bet-